

The Relationship Between College Students' Perceived Stress Levels and Future Outlook

Ashley K. Goldstein

Department of Psychology, University of Nevada, Las Vegas

PSY 490 Section 1011: Capstone in Psychology

Dr. Vitela

November 9, 2024

The Relationship Between College Students' Perceived Stress Levels and Future Outlook

Many college students struggle to adapt to their new environments, meet rigorous academic demands, and navigate societal pressure to determine their place in the world. This combination of challenges often leads to stress and stress-related symptoms, which can result in distorted cognitive states and pessimistic feelings about the future. These negative outlooks may create a self-perpetuating cycle where stress reinforces pessimistic thinking, and this pessimistic thinking increases stress. Though many studies examine the impact of stress and other health-related factors on students' well-being and future outlook, few investigate how stress affects students' perceived future outlook (PFO) and their sense of future success. Given the importance of this developmental period on one's future success and overall health, understanding the relationship between stress and PFO is essential.

When considering PFO, it is important to examine the effects of stress on academic success. Wu and Yang (2023) assessed the relationship between stress and late bedtimes among Chinese college students and the relationship between perceived health and academic performance using questionnaires and preexisting databases. Their study found that life stress and uncertainty stress were positively correlated with late bedtimes, which, in turn, were positively associated with self-reported health problems and negative academic performance (Wu & Yang, 2023). These findings suggest that stress can significantly impact real-world performance, potentially influencing students' futures and their perception of future success.

The findings from Wu and Yang's study raise questions about the factors that can positively influence students' perceived stress and PFO, which are explored in studies by Xue et al. (2024) and by Mingming, Lian, and Huiping (2024). Xue et al. investigated the relationship between self-continuity and depression among Chinese college students, while also assessing

whether social support and the presence of meaning could reduce depression. They found that future self-continuity and depression were negatively correlated, and self-continuity and social support could mitigate depression among college students (Xue et al., 2024). This study suggests that negative mental health symptoms can be alleviated by a strong sense of self and active efforts to align with one's future goals, which could lead to a more positive PFO.

Similarly, Mingming, Lian, and Huiping (2024) conducted a study examining the mitigating effects of meaning in life on the relationship between stress and suicidal ideation among Chinese college students. Using data from questionnaires measuring personal hassle stress, negative life event stress, academic stress, and suicidal ideation, they found that meaning in life could reduce the positive association between personal hassle stress and suicidal ideation (Mingming, Lian, & Huiping, 2024). These findings emphasize the severe effects of stress on future outlook, explicitly identifying a mitigating factor for stress's negative impacts on PFO. Additionally, they suggest that a sense of meaning and positive views on one's place in the world and future can lessen the stress experienced by students and the negative impacts this can have on one's PFO.

As discussed previously, depressed mood and depression are common mental health concerns that college students face alongside stress. In a study conducted by Feng et al. (2024), healthy, non-depressed Chinese college students completed a questionnaire examining the relationship between stress, rumination stages, and depressive mood and depression. This study found that stress positively predicted depression through both types of rumination, even when daily stress was managed (Feng et al., 2024). These results support the notion that stress and resulting rumination can increase depressive states, potentially creating a maladaptive cycle of cognitive distortion that impedes students' ability to approach situations level-headedly.

Based on the literature reviewed, it is hypothesized that there will be a small, negative correlation between perceived stress levels and PFO among college students. As previously discussed, Feng et al. (2024) found that stress can lead to rumination, which can increase depressive states, and Xue et al. (2024) found that high depressive states correlated with low self-continuity. Given the similarities between self-continuity and PFO and the links between stress and depression, it seems plausible that the hypothesis will be supported.

Method

Participants

Participants for this study were recruited via convenience sampling by scanning a QR code placed on bulletin boards found within the University of Nevada, Las Vegas (UNLV) student union and library. A total of 15 participants were included, nine being females and six males. The age range for females was 19-24, whereas the age range for males was 20-23. Regarding ethnicity, four students identified as White, three as Black, two as Hispanic, and six as Asian. When it comes to socioeconomic background, seven of the students indicated they were from medium socioeconomic backgrounds, five from high socioeconomic backgrounds, and three from low socioeconomic backgrounds. The participants were informed via the information section of the QR code flyer that they could opt out of the study at any time and that students from any major could participate.

Materials

This study used an online survey via Google Forms, which was accessed through a link present in the original QR code. The survey consisted of Likert scale questions assessing perceived stress levels and perceived future outlook (PFO). More specifically, participants were

asked to gauge their stress and how positively they felt about their future on scales of 1-5, with one indicating “strongly disagree” and five indicating “strongly agree.” Before being presented with the survey link, participants were shown a separate informational page that described the purpose of the study, informed them of their anonymity and right to opt-out at any time, asked for an email address, provided demographic questions, and provided a checkbox to indicate their consent to participate. Students were informed on this information page that they would receive daily reminder emails regarding the surveys.

Procedure

Participants were asked to complete the survey three times a day with at least 6 hours between responses over four weeks. The six-hour interval was chosen because the earliest college classes typically start at 8:30 a.m., allowing students to complete surveys at three key times: morning, midday, and evening. The survey was untimed and could be completed at any time in any location, but responses were time-stamped. An email was sent out at 8 a.m. daily reminding students to complete the survey three times that day with the link to the survey and requirements. Responses were excluded from the analysis if the student did not adhere to the time-based requirements. All responses were automatically recorded in Google Forms and averaged at the end of the four weeks. The averaged scores were then entered into an Excel spreadsheet for analysis.

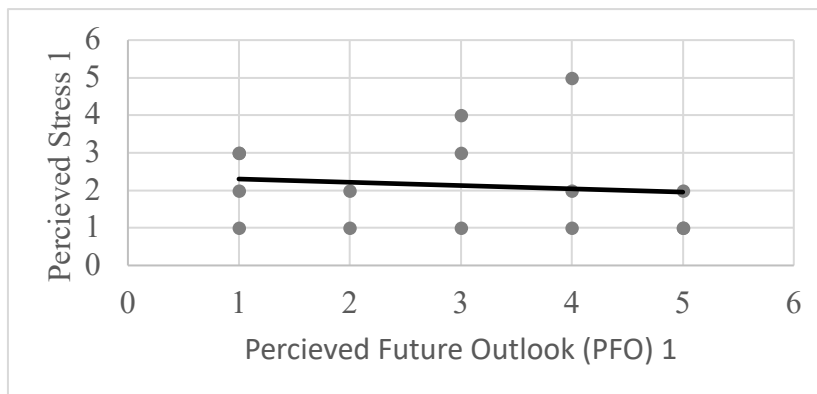
Results

The goal of this study was to analyze the correlation between perceived stress levels and perceived future outlook (PFO) among college students. It was hypothesized that perceived stress would have a small negative correlation with PFO, with a correlation coefficient between -

0.10 and -0.30. This range was based on the small negative correlations found in Mingming, Lian, and Huiping's (2024) study, where all three dimensions of stress (academic, personal hassle, and negative life events) had correlation coefficients of $r = -0.11$ ($p < .01$), $r = -0.15$ ($p < .01$), and $r = -0.13$ ($p < .01$), respectively with suicidal ideation. Pearson correlation coefficients were calculated to determine the strength and direction of relationships between perceived stress and PFO. The data collected resulted in the following correlation coefficient: $r = -0.11$. This finding indicates a statistically significant small negative correlation ($p < 0.05$) between perceived stress levels and PFO. See Figure for display of the results.

Figure 1

The Relationship between Perceived Stress and Perceived Future Outlook (PFO)



Discussion

This study shed light on the relationship between perceived stress and perceived future outlook (PFO) among college students. The hypothesis that perceived stress and PFO would have a small negative correlation was supported by the findings. This result suggests that stress reduction could be a plausible intervention to improve PFO in students, which may, in turn, increase their performance and reduce stress altogether.

The results align with the data and conclusions drawn by previous related studies. As described by Xue et al. (2023), having a positive sense of future self-continuity could predict lower levels of depression. Furthermore, as explored by Feng et al. (2024), daily perceived stress could predict depressive mood and depression within students through state rumination, which suggests that intense stress could lead to negative thinking and mindsets within students. It is possible that the participants involved in this study were impacted by the ruminating factors related to stress, causing them to think negatively about their futures when this stress was elevated. Depression could have also acted as a confounding variable between stress and PFOs.

Though this study provides valuable insights into the relationship between perceived stress and PFO, it is important to acknowledge several limitations. One limitation is the sample size, which is rather restrictive due to the constraints of convenience sampling. Similarly, this study's participants originated from one college in the United States, which may limit the generalizability of the findings. Furthermore, this study does not account for other factors influencing PFO, which might be important in understanding and addressing PFOs and stress.

Future research could benefit from implementing an experimental design with a larger, more diverse sample of participants. For example, researchers could introduce high-stress and low-stress conditions to determine if stress directly influences perceptions of the future. Randomly assigned participants would be asked to complete similar surveys before and after the stress-inducing interventions to gauge changes and determine causality. In the end, these improvements could provide a more well-rounded understanding of the relationship between perceived stress and PFO and inform institutions of how to better serve students.

References

- Feng, G., Xu, X., Wu, J., & Lei, J. (2024). The temporal dynamics of perceived stress and depression in college students: An ecological momentary assessment. *PsyCh Journal*, 1-9. <https://doi.org/10.1002/pchj.803>
- Mingming, C., Lian, X., & Huiping, Z. (2024). Stress and suicidal ideation among Chinese college students: The role of meaning in life. *Death Studies*, 48(10), 1121-1128. <https://doi.org/10.1080/07481187.2024.2305336>
- Wu, D., & Yang, T. (2020). Late bedtime, uncertainty stress among Chinese college students: impact on academic performance and self-rated health. *Psychology, Health & Medicine*, 28(10), 2915-2926. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13548506.2022.2067337>
- Xue, L., Yan, Y., Fan., H., Zhang, L. Wang., S., & Chen, L. (2023). Future self-continuity and depression among college students: The role of presence of meaning and perceived social support. *Journal of Adolescence*, 95(7), 1463-1477. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jad.12219>